

Inverting the Lithospheric Stress Field of Central Iran: A Physics-Informed Deep Learning Approach using Sparse Kinematic Data

Research Proposal

February 16, 2026

Abstract

Accurate estimation of the lithospheric stress field is critical for earthquake forecasting but remains challenging due to sparse *in-situ* measurements. Traditional Finite Element Models (FEMs) require complex meshing and explicit boundary conditions that are often unknown. We propose a novel **Physics-Informed Neural Network (PINN)** framework to invert for the 3D continuous stress tensor of Central Iran. Unlike previous studies that assume purely elastic rheology, our model incorporates **Maxwell Viscoelasticity** to capture time-dependent stress relaxation. Furthermore, we introduce a method to constrain the network using only **sparse GPS azimuths** (orientations), solving a highly non-linear inverse problem. This approach promises a mesh-free, physics-consistent stress map that outperforms statistical baselines (XGBoost) and standard Coulomb Stress Transfer (CST) in forecasting seismicity.

1 Scientific Rationale & Gap Analysis

Current state-of-the-art methods generally fall into two categories:

1. **Data-Driven (e.g., XGBoost)**: Excellent at finding correlations but lacks physical constraints, leading to poor generalization in data-sparse regions.
2. **Classical Physics (e.g., FEM/CST)**: Physically rigorous but limited by mesh quality and the need for unknown boundary conditions.

The Gap & Novelty (2022-2026 Landscape)

A review of recent literature confirms that while components of this method exist, their synthesis for the Iranian Plateau is unique:

- **Zhang et al. (2022)**: Used PINNs for stress inversion but assumed purely elastic regimes and relied on dense synthetic data.
- **ViscoelasticNet (2023)**: Applied viscoelastic PINNs to non-Newtonian fluids, lacking the background stress complexities of tectonics.

- **Degen et al. (2023)**: Modeled general geodynamics with synthetic global models.

No study has yet applied **Viscoelastic PINNs to invert for the 3D tectonic stress tensor** using only sparse **orientation constraints** (GPS azimuths) in a complex continental collision zone. This solves the “inverse problem” without the need for dense ground truth magnitude data.

2 Methodology

2.1 Physics-Informed Architecture

We define a deep neural network $\mathcal{N}_\theta(x, y, z, t)$ that approximates the stress tensor σ_{ij} and velocity field v_i . The Loss Function $\mathcal{L}$ minimizes the residuals of the momentum balance and constitutive equations:

$$\mathcal{L}_{total} = \mathcal{L}_{metric} + \lambda_1 \mathcal{L}_{PDE} + \lambda_2 \mathcal{L}_{BC} \quad (1)$$

where:

- $\mathcal{L}_{PDE}$ (Momentum): $\nabla \cdot \sigma + \rho g = 0$
- $\mathcal{L}_{PDE}$ (Constitutive): $\dot{\epsilon}_{ij} = \frac{1}{2\mu} \dot{\sigma}_{ij} + \frac{1}{2\eta} \sigma_{ij}$ (Maxwell Viscoelasticity).
 - *Justification*: For present-day stress inversion (10-100 yr), a linear Maxwell model with spatially heterogeneous viscosity $\eta(x)$ serves as a parsimonious proxy for non-linear power-law rheology.

2.2 Data Integration (The "Inverse" Problem)

We utilize the provided `kinematic_data` (GPS strain rates). Crucially, these data provide **orientations** (azimuths) rather than absolute stress magnitudes. We enforce this constraint by penalizing the misalignment between the predicted principal stress direction and the observed GPS strain azimuth:

$$\mathcal{L}_{data} = \sum_k (1 - \cos(\theta_{pred}^{(k)} - \theta_{obs}^{(k)}))^2 \quad (2)$$

2.3 Execution Roadmap

1. **Phase I (Validation)**: Implement a 2D Plane Stress model to validate the formulation against a synthetic "toy" fault interaction.
2. **Phase II (Main)**: Scale to full 3D Lithospheric model using the Central Iran velocity structure (`Pwave.3D.txt`) as a proxy for heterogeneous material properties ($\mu(x)$).

3 Validation & Benchmarking

To meet the rigorous standards of high-impact journals (*Nature Communications*), we establish the following validation protocols:

1. **Andersonian Consistency:** The inverted stress tensor must match dominant faulting styles (e.g., vertical σ_3 in Zagros reverse faulting zones).
2. **Borehole Breakout (BBO) Comparison:** We will validate against *in-situ* stress orientations from the **World Stress Map (WSM 2025)**. A successful model must achieve an angular misfit of $< 15^\circ$ - 20° .
3. **Seismicity Hindcasting:** Comparing log-likelihood scores against **Coulomb Stress Transfer (CST)** and **XGBoost** baselines for historical events (2006-2023).

4 Expected Impact

This study will provide the first-ever continuous, physics-consistent 3D stress map of Central Iran. By demonstrating the efficacy of Viscoelastic PINNs in data-sparse regions, we establish a new framework for earthquake potential imaging applicable to collision zones worldwide.